uphold balanced ecological and environmental protection and preservation standards, transparent assessment of project cost and transfer skills and technology to help the running and maintenance of assets created by local communities. Not least, India emphasized that connectivity projects must be pursued in a manner that respects sovereignty and territorial integrity. Clearly, concerns about the so-called China-Pakistan Economic Corridor and experiences in its periphery shaped India's position. Since then, the global conversation on connectivity has expanded, much of it in line with India's thinking.

It is actually the final set of realities between India and China that are going to be critical: when China is really becoming global and India, at the same time, is moving towards a bigger role in world affairs. Reconciling their aspirations and interests will require maturity of leadership in both nations, as well as the systemic skills of diplomacy. The established set of historical issues, especially border differences, will probably continue to influence the nature of the ties. Their impact on public perception of China is only growing with the passage of time. But new variables could also enter the calculation, some more benign, others less so. A lot will depend on how consciously and effectively both countries steer the relationship into more positive domains. Those who have a better visualization of what is at stake will obviously support such endeavours.

Getting used to each other's larger footprint will not be easy for either nation. Just as China seeks to raise its profile in South Asia, India too will gradually do so in South-East Asia and East Asia. The maritime domain, by its nature, will be particularly given to such activities. India is used to thinking of China only to the North; its presence in the South will mean something else. But this is also an arena where India holds some geographical, historical and cultural advantages.

As they both rise, albeit at a differential rate and from an uneven start, much would depend on perceptions of each other's attitudes. What it could boil down to is an overall sense of whether each is sufficiently accommodative of the other's rise. From India's perspective, how open China will be to its permanent membership of the UN Security Council will be one factor. The opportunity for text-based negotiations could provide an answer.